Useful Tools

Tools that make PHP development easier. None is required for the course, but most of them are used daily by PHP developers.

Designing databases

MySQL Workbench

Download (free Community edition) — Windows, macOS, Linux

Draw your tables, columns and relations as a diagram, and let Workbench generate the `CREATE TABLE` SQL for you. It also works the other way: connect it to an existing database and it draws the diagram.

Useful vocabulary:

- **EER diagram**: the visual model of your tables and their relations.
- **Forward engineer**: diagram → SQL script / database.
- **Reverse engineer**: existing database → diagram.

Demonstrated by the trainer during the session.

Browsing and querying databases

Tool	Databases	Notes
DB Browser for SQLite	SQLite	Open the `.db` files of modules 05 and 07
VS Code extension *SQLite Viewer*	SQLite	Click a `.db` file in VS Code
Adminer	MySQL, PostgreSQL, SQLite…	A single PHP file; included in the module 06 Docker setup
phpMyAdmin	MySQL / MariaDB	Web interface found on most PHP hosting
DBeaver	almost all	Free, powerful desktop client
MySQL Workbench	MySQL	Also a good query tool (see above)

Editor

Tool	What for
VS Code	Free editor used in this course
PHP Intelephense (VS Code extension)	Autocompletion, go to definition, error highlighting
PHP Debug (VS Code extension) + Xdebug	Breakpoints and step-by-step debugging
PhpStorm	The reference PHP IDE (paid, free for students)

Local PHP environment

Tool	What for
Laravel Herd	PHP in one click on Windows and macOS (works for any PHP project)
Docker Desktop	Run MySQL, PostgreSQL or a whole server stack in containers (module 06)

The PHP ecosystem

Tool	What for
Composer	PHP's package manager: install libraries, autoload your classes (next step after this course)
Packagist	The catalog of libraries installable with Composer
PHPStan	Finds bugs in your code without running it
PHP-CS-Fixer	Formats your code automatically to a standard style
PHPUnit	Automated tests

Learning and reference

Resource	What for
php.net/manual	The official documentation. Tip: `php.net/str_contains` opens a function's page directly
PHP: The Right Way	Good practices, in short chapters
3v4l.org	Run a PHP snippet online on every PHP version: perfect to check "since which version does this work?"
regex101.com	Test regular expressions (choose the *PCRE* flavor, the one PHP uses)